bother searching and processing information by myself when I can just ask the oracle? This could put out of business not only search engines but also much of the news industry and advertising industry. Why read a newspaper when I can just ask my oracle what's new? And what's the purpose of advertisements when I can just ask the oracle what to buy?

And even these scenarios don't really capture the big picture. What we are talking about is potentially the end of human history. Not the end of history, but the end of its human-dominated part. History is the interaction between biology and culture; between our biological needs and desires for things like food, sex and intimacy and our cultural creations like religions and laws. The history of the Christian religion, for example, is a process through which mythological stories and church laws influenced how humans consume food, engage in sex and build intimate relationships, while the myths and laws themselves were simultaneously shaped by underlying biological forces and dramas. What will happen to the course of history when computers play a larger and larger role in culture and begin producing stories, laws and religions? Within a few years AI could eat the whole of human culture – everything we have created over thousands of years – digest it and begin to gush out a flood of new cultural artefacts.

We live cocooned by culture, experiencing reality through a cultural prism. Our political views are shaped by the reports of journalists and the opinions of friends. Our sexual habits are influenced by what we hear in fairy tales and see in movies. Even the way we walk and breathe is nudged by cultural traditions, such as the military discipline of soldiers and the meditative exercises of monks. Until very recently, the cultural cocoon we lived in was woven by other humans. Going forward, it will be increasingly designed by computers.

At first, computers will probably imitate human cultural prototypes, writing humanlike texts and composing humanlike music. This doesn't mean computers lack creativity; after all, human artists do the same. Bach didn't compose music in a vacuum; he was deeply influenced by previous musical creations, as well as by biblical stories and other pre-existing cultural artifacts. But just as human artists like Bach can break with tradition and innovate, computers too can make cultural innovations, composing music or making images that are somewhat different from anything previously produced by humans. These innovations will in turn influence the next generation of computers, which will increasingly deviate